

One Year After:

PILGRIMS TO KENNEDY'S GRAVE

The tragedy of President Kennedy's assassination still tugs at the emotions of millions of people, and its consequences extend to every facet of political life. The tumult has barely subsided but already Kennedy's burial site has become a place of national pilgrimage. His modest grave in Arlington Cemetery, enclosed by a simple white picket fence, attracts thousands of visitors each day, and the number will swell to about three million, even before the tide of summer vacationers sweeps into Washington.

No bronze plaques or marble statues adorn the site. Only two small headstones, flanking the grave, bear inscriptions, and these are mere identifications of the Kennedy's two babies who died in childbirth. John F. Kennedy's grave is mounded over by a few evergreen boughs, some of which were placed there by Mrs Kennedy. Uniform caps, representing the armed services, still repose on the boughs, the same caps that were placed there last November by the honour guard. Atop the grave is a gas-fed torch which burns day and night.

Fresh flowers are placed in the enclosure every day, sometimes sent by family members or close friends, but most often brought by anonymous visitors. Frequently, groups and organisations send delegations to conduct a memorial service and to lay a wreath besides the grave. Soldiers of the Third Infantry Regiment, who regularly perform ceremonial tasks around Washington, stand guard, and assist visitors in placing flowers. They also help to direct the long lines of visitors who file through Arlington to pass respectfully around the grave.

In good weather, about 10,000 people a day come to pay their respects. At weekends, the total swells. Some pause to say a brief prayer; many go away with tear-stained faces. Most, however, walk slowly around the fence, absorbed in their own thoughts and memories, saying nothing.

Please acknowledge: photographs by CURT GUNTHER

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